



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 21

# MARYLAND

## WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

*Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Maryland's family courts and child-welfare system.*

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# 30

MARYLAND FAMILIES ON RECORD · 55  
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 4 MONTHS  
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED  
**APRIL 24, 2026**

COUNTIES REPRESENTED  
**10 OF 24**

COMPILED BY  
**MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM**

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

# MARYLAND AT A GLANCE.

Across 30 Maryland families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

|                                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                                         |                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>CHILDREN IMPACTED</div> <div>55</div> <div>30 of 30 families reporting with kids</div> | <div>MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES</div> <div>\$6,000</div> <div>per reporting family</div> | <div>MEDIAN MONTHS LOST</div> <div>4</div> <div>of parenting time</div> | <div>WENT PRO SE</div> <div>33.3%</div> <div>20.0% after running out of money</div> |
| <div>SUBMISSIONS</div> <div>30</div>                                                        | <div>AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY</div> <div>1.8</div>                                    | <div>REPORTING FAMILIES</div> <div>30 of 30</div>                       | <div>COUNTIES REPRESENTED</div> <div>10</div>                                       |

## WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Maryland families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MARYLAND FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY               | RESPONSES | MEDIAN  | MEAN      | TOTAL REPORTED |
|--------------------------------|-----------|---------|-----------|----------------|
| Attorney Fees                  | 30        | \$6,000 | \$52,800  | \$1,584,000    |
| Lost Wages                     | 30        | \$0     | \$111,967 | \$3,359,000    |
| Other Court Fees               | 30        | \$0     | \$590     | \$17,700       |
| Therapy / Evaluations          | 30        | \$0     | \$900     | \$27,000       |
| Reunification Services         | 30        | \$0     | \$147     | \$4,400        |
| GAL Fees                       | 30        | \$0     | \$1,767   | \$53,000       |
| Asset Loss <sup>1</sup>        | 30        | \$0     | —         | —              |
| Estimated Median Family Impact | —         | \$6,000 | —         | —              |

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$0) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

|                           |                        |              |
|---------------------------|------------------------|--------------|
| Median months lost        | <div><div></div></div> | 4 0.3 yrs    |
| Mean months lost          | <div><div></div></div> | 16 1.3 yrs   |
| Total across all families | <div><div></div></div> | 473 39.4 yrs |

## 03 WHO IS REPORTING · MARYLAND

Most families documenting in Maryland are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

## CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

## CASE STATUS

|                            |             |    |     |
|----------------------------|-------------|----|-----|
| Unknown                    | <div></div> | 13 | 43% |
| Currently involved / "S... | <div></div> | 12 | 40% |
| Case closed (more tha...   | <div></div> | 3  | 10% |
| Case closed (within th...  | <div></div> | 1  | 3%  |
| I am currently stuck in... | <div></div> | 1  | 3%  |

## SYSTEM AFFECTED

|                           |             |    |     |
|---------------------------|-------------|----|-----|
| Family Court Only         | <div></div> | 14 | 47% |
| Both Family Court and ... | <div></div> | 8  | 27% |
| Unknown                   | <div></div> | 5  | 17% |
| CPS (Child Protective ... | <div></div> | 3  | 10% |

## DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

## TIME IN SYSTEM

|                   |             |   |     |
|-------------------|-------------|---|-----|
| 1 – 3 years       | <div></div> | 6 | 20% |
| 3 – 5 years       | <div></div> | 6 | 20% |
| Over 10 years     | <div></div> | 4 | 13% |
| 1-3 years         | <div></div> | 3 | 10% |
| 6 months – 1 year | <div></div> | 3 | 10% |

## CUSTODY STATUS

|                           |             |    |     |
|---------------------------|-------------|----|-----|
| Visitation Only           | <div></div> | 12 | 40% |
| No Contact / Total Los... | <div></div> | 9  | 30% |
| 50/50 Joint               | <div></div> | 3  | 10% |
| Full Custody              | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |
| Partial / Shared          | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |

## GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

## TOP COUNTIES

|                   |             |    |     |
|-------------------|-------------|----|-----|
| Unknown           | <div></div> | 13 | 43% |
| Allegheny         | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |
| Carroll           | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |
| Howard county     | <div></div> | 1  | 3%  |
| Washington County | <div></div> | 1  | 3%  |
| Prince George's   | <div></div> | 1  | 3%  |

## TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

|                            |             |    |     |
|----------------------------|-------------|----|-----|
| Family Court False Ac...   | <div></div> | 10 | 33% |
| Other: (Short answer)      | <div></div> | 7  | 23% |
| Child Protective Servic... | <div></div> | 3  | 10% |
| Family Court               | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |
| High Conflict Divorce      | <div></div> | 2  | 7%  |

**05 PARENT VOICES — MARYLAND**

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



*The system came in and ripped my daughter out of my arms with no due process and created years of severe, debilitating separation anxiety for her.*

— NICOLE

**ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS**

Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony [...]

— MARYLAND PARENT · ANONYMOUS

**MORE VOICES FROM MARYLAND**

The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!

— RACHEL

CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of [...]

— TYLER

CPS has filed to terminate my rights completely for my two older children. I was never informed of the 15-22 months "timeframe" they lied on every single court report and never acknowledged any progress I made

— HANNAH

Have destroyed my faith in the country live and fought and killed for. I lost my children, my life financial I'm struggling and I don't wish to happen to anyone.

— ABU

## 05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because [...]*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They are taking a dedicated full-time mother almost completely away from her children. And gave them to my ex-husband who was never present.

— JESSICA

Ex and wife never wanted the children. They just didn't want me to have the children. Covert-insidious form of abuse. Children aged out of the system. Ex hasn't contacted children in months/years. Adult children are still traumatized and in therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broke mother and dimmed three childrens lights spirits and souls causing severe distrust and perpetual fear of abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is been absolutely devastating for me but terroristically traumatizingfir my intentionally parented baby who's world has been turned upside down for profit. I am beyond mortified but determined to correct my mistakes and rescue my Baby Girl

— NIKKI

Separated my two minor children. Placed my daughter in the arms of an abuser. Missed Drs. Appointments for chronically ill daughter and then stated they are just routine appointments when I told the court her dad was not taking her while in his custody

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn us apart lost of stability

— SCOTT

It's taken away our ability to advocate and protect our children. They're in danger everyday and we can't do anything to help them. No matter how we fight to protect them it's twisted as abuse towards the ex partner.....never do they look at the abuse towards the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system treated her word as fact and her lies as evidence. Treated me as a criminal

— WILL

## 05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*To the mothers suffering from post partum dealing with the threat of having your infant taken is inhumane to all mothers but especially the ones in this delicate time contact me if need be I dont mind I would love to expose this corruption, my instagram is @blissfullyblunt I am [...]*

— REBECCA

Broken my soul Made me sick I lost so much

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has failed me. Not allowing me to be a father

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered it entirely

— SHERRI

The system has allowed my children's father's mother to intervene on his behalf of ONE of our three children, his entire eight years of existence. While trusting my other two children to be with me full-time, they have allowed this woman to abuse, my son, myself and my entire [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has empowered my ex-wife with control, removed my son from my life, removed my daughter from my life. It was beaten me mentally as I just want to love my kids and give them the best things that I can but am no longer able to due to financial burden of using a lawyer [...]

— JOHN

My family and their associates all assisted in attempted murder, and kidnapping of my child. There is trafficking and other crimes involved. Several counties and the FBI refused assistance when reported repeatedly for over a year. They stole my home my child and my finances.

— KACIE

After having primary custody for over 8 years and being the primary caregiver for 14 years. the court decided to change custody in because of a military relocation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

23 Maryland parents submitted ranked quotes. 23 appear in this report; the remainder are available at [standwithmeg.com/md](https://standwithmeg.com/md).

## 06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

### WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Maryland report comes from Maryland respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Maryland — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 30 Maryland families reporting here are not the universe of Maryland families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

### METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through [standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey](https://standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey). Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

### ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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